ments. Singhdeo excused himself by citing an engagement; a week ago, he went to south Chhattisgarh to tour and inspect departments under his charge, while the CM was in the north, touring villages as per his Bhent Mulaqat schedule.

The BJP has termed Baghel's outreach programme an eyewash. "Bhent Mulaqat should be renamed *badtameezi aur daant*," said former CM Raman Singh after videos emerged of Baghel reprimanding a woman in Surajpur on May 8 for blaming the police over a matter. As criticism mounted, Baghel was forced to express regret.

Back in Rajapur, one of the villages under the Sitapur assembly segment, CM Baghel asks the audience if they have received all payment instalments of the paddy procurement scheme. At the end, Baghel announces plans to open schools, a stadium and a police post in the area, besides making Rajapur a sub tehsil.

The convoy of helicopters then moves to Sarmana village. A large number of people come up with personal problems, many of them related to land revenue management or securing caste or tribe certificates. Chhaya Mishra, a B.Sc. student, tells Baghel that she comes from a family of Brahmins but is forced to do menial jobs. She demands a toilet, a job and financial assistance. Baghel tells her about dignity of labour and tells her about the schemes she could benefit from. He asks if everyone was getting the promised 35 kg of rice and kerosene under the PDS (public distribution scheme). A girl asks Baghel to show her the school he studied in. "We would walk five kilometres to school every day," the visibly proud CM says, asking the district collector to organise trips for students who want to visit his school in Durg district.

Every now and then, Baghel reminds villagers of galloping inflation or prices of cooking gas, taunting BJP leaders who protested when cylinder prices were Rs 450. With assembly election 18 months away, Baghel is clearly testing the waters. The BJP, till now, hasn't matched him in energy and activity. But it won't remain that way for long. A fight is in the offing. ■



CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

INTERVIEW | BHUPESH BAGHEL

"Our schemes aren't freebies, they help productivity"

Partaking of a traditional Oraon tribal meal of kurthi daal, tomato chutney and lakra at the house of Rajnath Singh, a resident of Bhainsakhar village in the state's Ambikapur district, CM BHUPESH BAGHEL spoke to INDIA TODAY on the Bhent Mulaqat Abhiyan programme, his government's schemes and plans to take on the BJP in the upcoming 2023 assembly election. Excerpts